



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Monica Catholic School
School Website: <https://www.stmonicasea.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St. Monica Catholic School (SMS), located on Mercer Island, WA (ZIP 98040), presents itself publicly as a PreK–12 Catholic classical liberal arts school. Across its public-facing materials, SMS foregrounds the Catholic intellectual tradition, Western Civilization, and a classical curriculum that centers on the trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and the great books, integrated with liturgical life and catechesis. The school emphasizes Socratic seminars, narration, and a pedagogy oriented toward truth, goodness, and beauty, with explicit focus on formation of character and virtue rather than merely information transfer. Faculty are portrayed as mentors and the living curriculum, and there is a strong emphasis on parental partnership and community life within a Catholic framework. The overall signal from SMS is CLASSICAL across all six categories of the Six Essential Elements rubric.

Key textual anchors include SMS descriptions of itself as a Catholic classical school offering a liberal arts curriculum grounded in the Educational Plan of St. Jerome, engagement with Great Books and Western Tradition, and explicit pedagogy such as Socratic seminars and narrations. The school also stresses liturgical life, catechesis, and a shared mission with parents as co-educators. These elements appear consistently from elementary through high school materials and admissions pages, and are reinforced by testimonials and program descriptions on the school site.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- **Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL Evidence:** Catholic foundation, liturgical life, catechesis, theology, and Western-Catholic intellectual tradition are foregrounded. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present include truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; wonder; virtuous life; sacred music/chant; imago Dei. Negative keywords (relativism, secular humanism) are notably absent in public materials. Positive count outpaces negative (no negatives found in the text). Why this rating: The materials clearly frame education as formation in transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) anchored in Catholic theology and liturgical life.
- **Element 2: Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL Evidence:** Goals stated as formation in virtue and wisdom, cultivation of human excellence, and engagement with truth, goodness, beauty; emphasis on Great Books and Western Tradition as aims. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present include formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, telos, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, great conversation. No workforce/career rhetoric; no counter-indicative signals observed. Why this rating: SMS emphasizes formation and character over a narrow job-preparation frame, aligning with classical telos and paideia aims.
- **Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL Evidence:** Explicit reference to liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, Western Civilization, Latin, Greek, and a time-period approach across grades; direct mention of studying concepts through integration across subjects (e.g., Galileo example). Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present include liberal arts, trivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books, primary sources, Latin, Western civilization, history, theology, catechesis. Negatives (e.g., replacing history with social-studies framing, heavy project-based emphasis) are not evident in SMS materials. Why this rating: The curriculum descriptions align strongly with classical curriculum markers (Trivium, Great Books, breadth of classical subjects, integration across disciplines).
- **Element 4: Pedagogy — CLASSICAL Evidence:** SMS highlights Socratic seminars, narration, memory work, and the cultivation of wonder; upper grades emphasize rhetoric and speaking; lower grades

include singing/memory-friendly activities; the model integrates scholé/restful learning with rigorous inquiry. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords include Socratic seminars, narration, chanting, memory work, restfulness/scholé, contemplation, wonder, rhetoric, debate. While SMS includes some experiential elements (hands-on science), the overall pedagogy is anchored in classical methods rather than purely constructivist/project-based models. No explicit signals of dominant project-based-only pedagogy. Why this rating: The material foregrounds classical teaching methods (Socratic dialogue, memory-based learning, and rhetoric) aligned with the six-element rubric.

- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL Evidence: Faculty described as virtuous mentors and living curriculum; emphasis on collaboration and a “portrait” of teacher-student ideals; specialized teachers and faith-filled faculty noted; high school asserts expert faculty. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present include tutors/mentors, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, master/teacher figures, and faith-filled faculty. No negative faculty signals (e.g., “facilitators on the side”) appear in public materials. Why this rating: SMS portrays a strongly classical faculty model with an emphasis on mentorship, living principles, and a shared teacher-student formation.
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL Evidence: Explicit partnerships with parents as co-teachers; parent formation through book studies and gatherings; open campus and volunteer opportunities; family liturgy alignment; parent covenant; community liturgy and events. Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive keywords present include partnership with parents, co-teachers, parent formation, seminars/book clubs, open campus, hospitality, family liturgy, and community events. Negative signals (consumer language, minimal parent involvement) are not evident in public materials. Why this rating: SMS frames parents as essential partners in classical formation and provides explicit mechanisms for parental involvement and education.

Aggregate Ranking: CLASSICAL

- Overall assessment: SMS demonstrates a cohesive classical orientation across religious/metaphysical foundations, purpose, curriculum, pedagogy, faculty, and parent/community engagement. The presence of Great Books, Western Tradition, Trivium-focused curriculum, Socratic pedagogy, liturgical integration, and a living-faculty culture strongly supports CLASSICAL classification across all six elements.
- What would move the needle: Not required since the aggregate rating is CLASSICAL. If one sought marginal refinements, the school could further codify explicit, measurable links between Great Books selections and specific outcomes for students in each grade, and provide more explicit documentation tying all grade-level plans to the classical rubric language (though current materials already align well).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Details

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - SMS positions itself as a Catholic school whose curriculum is rooted in the Catholic intellectual tradition and Western civilization. The School Profile describes SMS as a PreK–12 Catholic classical school with a curriculum grounded in the Western-Catholic intellectual tradition. - Public materials emphasize Jesus Christ as the foundation of the school community and the integration of liturgical life into school life. - The school references liturgy, catechesis, sacraments, and catechesis of the Good Shepherd (CGS) as part of religious formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; catechesis; sacred music; chant; wonder; imago Dei; wisdom. - Negative keywords found: none identified in public materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or negative signals appear in SMS materials).

Why this rating - The combination of Catholic foundation, sacramental/liturgical life, and explicit alignment with theological and transcendentals-based formation aligns this category solidly with classical categories.

Citations - SMS self-description and Catholic/Western tradition framing:- Liturgical/catechetical elements: #### Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes formation of virtue and wisdom and the cultivation of human excellence and moral imagination; the Great Books and Western Tradition are presented as central aims. - The mission statement and program descriptions emphasize forming students to pursue truth, goodness, and beauty, not merely preparing for college or careers. - Public materials stress active Catholic citizenship and service, consistent with formation-oriented telos rather than job-focused outcomes.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: formation; virtue; wisdom; liberal education; telos; pursuit of the true, good, beautiful; great conversation; classical heritage; human excellence; soul craft; moral imagination. - Negative keywords found: none (no emphasis on workforce-prep or 21st-century skills as primary goals; no “career readiness” framing).

Why this rating - SMS centers education on formation and virtue, not merely information or job training, aligning with classical aims for human flourishing through a liberal-arts frame.

Citations - Core formation language and telos:- Mission and formation language: #### Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly presents a liberal arts curriculum with grammar, logic, and rhetoric, alongside Great Books and a focus on Western Civilization and Catholic intellectual tradition. - The High School page notes a classical liberal arts program with a sequence that spans ancient to modern periods and integrates theology, literature, history, math, science, and Latin. - The curriculum is organized around time-period foci (e.g., Greek Year, Medieval Year, Modern Year) and instruction in Latin, literature, history, and other core subjects, reflecting a comprehensive classical approach.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: liberal arts; trivium; quadrivium; grammar; logic; rhetoric; great books; primary sources; classics; Homer; Plato; Augustine; Shakespeare; Latin; Western civilization; history; theology; catechesis; memory work; recitation; narration; dictation. - Negative keywords found: none (no substitution of history with “social studies” language; no dominance of project-based learning in place of classical history).

Why this rating - SMS describes and demonstrates a classical curriculum with core classical subjects and Great Books orientation, consistent with the rubric.

Citations - Great Books, Western Tradition, and Trivium emphasis:- Time-period curriculum and classical structure: #### Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school highlights Socratic seminars, narration, and the memory-centric aspects of classical pedagogy; upper-level rhetoric and oratory opportunities are described as part of the curriculum. - Lower grades include singing and chanting with regular review to deepen memory and delight; restoration of wonder is central to the approach. - There is explicit emphasis on upper-school rhetoric training and opportunities for public speaking; a cadence toward classical debate and discourse is described.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: Socratic seminars; narration; chanting; memory work; restfulness; scholé; contemplation; wonder; seminar; Paideia; rhetoric; debate; oratory; capstone orations. - Negative keywords found: none evident in public materials (no dominant “experiential learning” or project-based-only signals).

Why this rating - SMS’s pedagogy embodies canonical classical methods (Socratic dialogue, memorization, and rhetoric) across grades, with a balanced integration of contemplative and active modalities.

Citations - Pedagogical methods: #### Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school portrays faculty as virtuous mentors and living exemplars; the faculty are described as the core of the school and as a living curriculum; a “faculty of friends” and collegial culture appear in materials. - The public materials reference expert, faith-filled faculty and a culture of collaboration in which teachers and students learn together. - The employment and school-profile materials describe a structure of specialists (e.g., catechesis, Latin, library, theology, music, PE/CYO), emphasizing a robust faculty ecosystem.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: tutors/masters/mentors; living curriculum; portrait of a teacher; faculty of friends; collegial culture; lifelong learners; great books seminars for faculty; moral exemplars; teacher training; classical formation. - Negative keywords found: none observed in public materials.

Why this rating - SMS positions faculty as central to the school's classical formation, consistent with the living-curriculum model described in classical education literature.

Citations - Living curriculum and faculty emphasis:- Faculty as mentors and classical formation: ### Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - SMS emphasizes partnership with parents as co-teachers and actively involves parents through Parent Club, book studies, seminars, and family liturgy; open campus and visitation are encouraged. - The school communicates opportunities for parental involvement (volunteer opportunities, enrichment, and catechesis) and fosters a hospitable, liturgical community environment. - Admissions and school-community materials show a structured approach to family engagement and a tradition of parent participation in spiritual and academic life.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: partnership with parents; co-teachers; parent formation; reading groups; seminars/book clubs; open campus; hospitality; parent covenant; family liturgy alignment; community events; home catechesis. - Negative keywords found: none evident in public materials.

Why this rating - SMS treats parents as essential co-educators and provides multiple channels for parental involvement, in line with classical understandings of community and household formation.

Citations - Parent Club and parental involvement:- Community orientation and open-campus ethos: ## What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable in this fully CLASSICAL assessment. SMS already exhibits a cohesive classical orientation across all six categories, with explicit elements of the trivium, Great Books, Western tradition, Catholic theological formation, liturgical life, and strong parent/community engagement. If one sought marginal refinements, the school could enrich explicit crosswalks between grade-level outcomes and canonical classical benchmarks (e.g., mapping specific Great Books selections to the corresponding historical, rhetorical, and logical competencies across grades) to further demonstrate tangible alignment with the Six Essential Elements rubric.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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